

Patrimonial Policing: Police Bias and Access to Justice in Liberia*

Benjamin S. Morse[†]

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[†]Ph.D. Candidate, Department of Political Science, MIT, bmorse@mit.edu

Abstract

Ensuring that rank-and-file officers adhere to standards of professionalism, fairness, and impartiality is a challenge for police departments the world over, but nowhere more so than in weak and fragile states. I examine whether officers of the Liberian National Police (LNP) discriminate against certain groups when resolving crimes, and whether this in turn leads to inequities in access to justice. Motivated by theories of bureaucratic bias and accountability, I test for discrimination along three dimensions: i) tasted-based discrimination against minorities, ii) discrimination against individuals with low socio-economic status, who may lack the skills and resources to hold police accountable through formal channels, and iii) discrimination against individuals without personal connections to government officials, who may lack the ability to hold police accountable through informal channels. Combining data from a conjoint experiment designed to elicit citizens' expectations about police discrimination with fine-grained data on nearly 2600 incidents of crime, I find no evidence of discrimination against minorities or low socio-economic status individuals but strong evidence of discrimination against those without personal connections to government officials. These results have important consequences for equity in access to justice as well as important implications for our understanding of bureaucratic accountability. In patrimonial bureaucracies, formal channels of accountability rooted in bureaucratic rules and procedures may be less important than informal channels rooted in personal connections to government elites.

1 INTRODUCTION

Impartiality in the exercise of power is a defining feature of legitimate policing (Tyler 2004). Yet police departments the world over face enduring challenges in trying to ensure that rank-and-file officers adhere to standards of professionalism, fairness, and impartiality. Because much of police work is discretionary and performed by small, autonomous teams that are difficult to monitor, rank-and-file officers often have ample room to abuse their authority or discriminate on the basis of their personal biases (Lipsky 1980). This is especially true of policing in weak and fragile states, where mid-level commanders often lack the resources to monitor their subordinates, and where citizens' ability to hold officers to account through formal reporting channels is limited.

To what extent do these conditions lead to inequities in access to justice? When victims report crimes to the police, do officers treat all victims equally? Or do they exhibit bias against poor, minority, or otherwise disadvantaged individuals, neglecting their cases while prioritizing those from wealthy or well-connected individuals? To what extent does this deter members of disadvantaged groups from reporting crimes in the first place? And what can the answers to these questions tell us about the sources of accountability problems and performance shortfalls within bureaucracies?

Despite a growing body of research on police discrimination in developed countries, evidence on the extent and nature of discrimination in developing countries — and in weak states in particular — remains limited. While a handful of scholars have documented patterns of police corruption and discrimination at traffic checkpoints (Robinson, Seim et al. 2018; Fried, Lagunes and Venkataramani 2010), few have considered whether discrimination plagues police investigations and creates inequities in access to justice; fewer still have considered what this tells us about the sources of bureaucratic accountability.

Identifying the magnitude and nature of police discrimination during investigations has been difficult in part due to a lack of fine-grained data on crime, crime reporting, and case outcomes for reported crimes, as well as by a lack of accompanying data on complainant background character-

istics. Such data are necessary if researchers are to identify differences in reporting patterns and case outcomes across groups that cannot be explained by alternative factors such as the nature or location of the crime, thereby suggesting discrimination.

To address this gap, I oversaw the administration of a crime victimization survey to a representative sample of 3600 residents of Monrovia, Liberia, one of sub-Saharan Africa's most crime-ridden cities.¹ Liberia is an especially "most likely" case for observing police discrimination because many of the factors that social science theories suggest would lead to discrimination — e.g., lack of oversight, poorly functioning channels of accountability, low pay, and capacity constraints — are particularly severe, and because the country's recent experience with civil conflict has made class and social divisions especially salient.

Respondents were asked if they or a member of their household was a victim of any of several types of crime in the past year. For each incident of crime, respondents were asked whether they reported the case to the police; those responding affirmatively were asked a follow-up set of questions on how they were treated, effortful actions the police may or may not have taken to solve their case, and case outcomes such as whether the perpetrator was ever brought to justice. In addition to data on these outcomes, the survey collected information on victims' background characteristics, the date and location of the crime, and the nearest police station, among other potentially confounding factors.

Empirically, my analysis is motivated by the intuition that individuals facing discrimination should be less likely to report their cases to the police, and when they do, they should report lower rates of satisfaction and less successful case outcomes. Within this framework, I test for evidence of discrimination along four dimensions, each linked to a particular theory of bureaucratic bias. First, I test whether officers exhibit "taste-based" discrimination against Liberia's minority Muslim population (Becker 1957), causing these individuals to report fewer crimes and to be less

¹ According to Afrobarometer data collected in 2016, 65 percent of the city's residents reported that they or someone they knew was a victim of theft in the past year, 35 percent reported that they or someone they knew was physically assaulted, and 78 percent reported that in the past year, they felt unsafe in their neighborhood "several times", "many times", or "always." These figures are the highest of any of the 36 capital cities covered by Afrobarometer's Round 6 Survey.

satisfied with how they were treated during those they did report. Second, motivated by “bargaining power” theories of discrimination in which bureaucrats exploit those least able to hold them to account through formal reporting channels (Banerjee et al. 2018; Banerjee, Mullainathan and Hanna 2013), I test whether officers exhibit discrimination against either the poor, who may lack the time and resources to report misconduct, or those with limited education, who may lack an understanding of the law or the literacy skills required to report misconduct. Finally, drawing on theories of patrimonial governance in which authorities exercise power on the basis of their personal relationships rather than rational-legal criteria (Weber 1964), I test for evidence that officers favor individuals with connections to elites in government, providing better treatment, exerting greater effort, and achieving more successful case outcomes.

As with all observational studies, the validity of my analysis rests on the assumption that unobserved factors do not account for the observed differences in case outcomes. I attempt to mitigate this risk by controlling for a large number of victim and crime-level factors, as well as by conducting an extensive set of supplementary analyses to diagnose, address, and rule out the most likely remaining sources of confounding. Despite these efforts, it is impossible to decisively rule out the risk of bias due to unobserved confounding. For this reason, I complement my analysis of crime-level data with a conjoint survey experiment designed to elicit citizens’ *expectations* about police discrimination. In the experiment, respondents were presented with a vignette in which a victim of crime reports their case to the police. The victims’ attributes varied independently along four dimensions: income, education, religion, and political connections. After being read the vignette, respondents were asked a series of questions about how they expected the police to handle the case.

My use of expectations as test for discrimination rests on the assumption that expectations are indeed reflective of reality. This too may be a strong assumption, as a large literature suggests that humans sometimes process information in ways that are systematically biased, leading to misperceptions (Campbell et al. 1960; Zaller et al. 1992; Nyhan and Reifler 2010). Yet this same literature also acknowledges that biased information processing is by no means the norm (Guess

and Coppock 2018), and that humans often have strong incentives to hold accurate beliefs and will readily update them in response to new information, regardless of whether it conforms to their priors (Bullock 2009; Bullock et al. 2015). Research also indicates that beliefs are most likely to be accurate when informed by personal experience, when the issues at hand are not highly politicized, and when accuracy incentives are strong, all of which weigh in favor of the view that Liberians' beliefs about the police are likely to be well-informed and reasonably accurate.

Nevertheless, the virtue of using both experimental and observational data is that they require distinct sets of assumptions. By using both in my analysis, I avoid the need to base my conclusions on any single assumption.

I organize my results into three sets of findings. First, I find little evidence to suggest that police exhibit taste-based discrimination against Liberia's minority Muslim population. Using crime-level data on reporting and complainant satisfaction, I find that Muslims are not significantly less likely to report crimes to the police, as compared to non-Muslims, and that when they do report, they are not significantly less likely to be satisfied with how they were treated or to experience successful case outcomes. These null results hold with and without controls for potential confounders, are close to zero, consistent across outcomes and specifications, and withstand a set of placebo tests for reporting biases and other most likely sources of unobserved confounding. They are also consistent with the results from the conjoint experiment: when Muslim victims report crimes to the police, respondents are just as likely to expect that officers will treat them with respect, investigate the case aggressively, and take other meaningful actions to resolve the case, as compared to crimes reported by Christian victims.

Evidence of discrimination against the poor and individuals with limited education is more mixed. On the one hand, the crime-level data indicates that these individuals are nearly just as likely to report crimes to the police as individuals with above median education or income. And when they do report, they are roughly just as likely to be satisfied with how they were treated and to experience successful case outcomes. However, results from the conjoint experiment reveal that citizens *expect* the police to discriminate against the poor, and to a lesser degree, against those who

are illiterate. On the composite index of expected police performance, being a poor is associated with .1 standard deviations lower performance. These seemingly contradictory results suggest the possibility of a gap between citizens' expectations and reality when it comes to discrimination by police against those least able to hold them accountable.

Examining this possibility in further detail, I find that expected discrimination is driven in part by respondents who have previously experienced petty corruption at the hands of the police, most often in the form informal fees linked to case investigations. And yet the crime-level data indicates these fees affect all citizens equally, regardless of their socio-economic status. Moreover, examining effects on the sub-components of index, I find that lower expected overall performance for the poor is also driven in part by the expectation that poor victims will not be charged informal fees, suggesting that lower expected performance derives not simply from discrimination but also from fewer resources available for investigation. Taken as a whole, I interpret these results as evidence that citizens misconstrue the police's "fee-for-service" model of service delivery as discrimination against the poor, when in fact the practice is applied without regard for victims' socio-economic status and closely linked to the lack of resources available to rank-and-file officers.

In contrast to the findings on (the absence of) discrimination against Muslims, the poor, and those with limited education, I find strong and consistent evidence that individuals who are related to elites in government receive better quality services from the police (or equivalently, discrimination against those without connections). As compared to those without connections, victims with connections are significantly more likely to report their case to the police, and when they do report, they are significantly more likely to be satisfied with how they were treated and to experience successful case outcomes. These patterns do not appear to reflect differences in the nature of crimes that occur, reporting biases, resources, or bargaining power outside the realm of interactions with the state.

Results from the conjoint experiment provide further evidence of favoritism towards politically connected individuals: when the victim in the vignette is politically connected, expectations of police performance improve by .08 standard deviations relative to vignettes in which the victim

is not politically connected.

Taken as a whole, these findings are consistent with the idea that, in countries where patrimonial forms of governance prevail and formal channels of accountability are weak or irrelevant, individuals with connections to elites in government are able to advocate for services through informal channels, by using elite patrons to pressure frontline services providers to perform on their behalf, thereby short-circuiting formal but largely ineffective channels linked to official reporting processes.

This conclusion is a departure from conventional explanations for bureaucratic bias and poor performance, which typically appeal to principal-agent problems between mid-to-upper-level officials and street-level bureaucrats. In Liberia, street-level officers do not discriminate against minorities and they do not exploit those who lack the skills and resources to hold them account, despite the challenges they face with inadequate compensation, lack of equipment, and limited support and oversight. Rather, it appears that accountability problems within the LNP stem from the fact that power is organized according to a patrimonial logic, with resources concentrated in the hands of Commanders and accessible only to those in the upper echelon of society.

2 THEORY

Like many street-level bureaucrats, police officers typically enjoy considerable discretion over how they perform their duties. It is common, for instance, for rank-and-file officers to make decisions about where to patrol, who to arrest, and which cases to prioritize for investigation. Police also tend to work in small, autonomous teams, often with only limited oversight from higher-level officials. In his seminal study of government bureaucracy, [Lipsky \(1980\)](#) argues that this combination of autonomy and discretion is common throughout government and gives rise to the role of street-level bureaucrats as de-facto “policy makers” whose personal preferences and biases influence the nature and quality of public services. When these preferences are at odds with official policy objectives, a potentially large discrepancy can arise between the policies that citizens experience and the

policies that policymakers intend. In the policing sector, studies have shown that officers operating autonomously and within their discretion are prone to racial bias when enforcing traffic violations (Goncalves, Mello et al. 2017; Lundman and Kaufman 2003), racial profiling when identifying potential suspects (Gelman, Fagan and Kiss 2007), and discrimination against minorities when investigating crimes (Eitle, D'Alessio and Stolzenberg 2002).

Problems of unequal treatment by street-level bureaucrats are not always the result of personal biases or “taste-based” discrimination, however. As Lipsky (1980, 107) points out, differential treatment can also result from capacity or resource constraints that force bureaucrats to ration services (e.g. by giving preferential access to those who seem most likely to benefit from services, triaging high-risk clients, or simply selecting those who are easiest or fastest to serve). Because rationing strategies may disproportionately exclude disadvantaged social groups, they can lead to unequal access to public services.

Most research on the causes and consequences of bureaucratic discrimination comes from developed countries. However, many of the factors that are believed to cause discrimination are especially pronounced in developing countries. Perhaps most notably, governments in these settings often underfund their agencies (Bardhan and Mookherjee 2006; Lin, Tao and Liu 2006), forcing bureaucrats to adopt “fee-for-service” models of service provision that inherently discriminate against the poor (Justesen and Bjørnskov 2014). Fee-for-service models are a particularly common obstacle for victims of crime, who often have to pay fees throughout the course of an investigation, from case registration, to transportation to the crime scene, to the detention of suspects (Hunt 2007; Kyed 2017).

In many developing-country settings, these problems are compounded by inadequate oversight and failures of accountability. As Rose-Ackerman (2004, 112) points out, resource constraints can provide a pretext for police officers to become “part-time bandits” who extort bribes from individuals and businesses to supplement their income.

The prevalence of monitoring challenges in developing countries can also provide an especially wide space for bureaucrats to discriminate based on ethnic or religious biases, which may be

especially strong to begin with due to the salience of these kinds of cleavages in these settings. Indeed, a large literature on distributive politics in developing countries documents discrimination in the provision of public services (Kramon and Posner 2013; Franck and Rainer 2012; Hicken 2011), with ethnic and religious minorities seemingly at greatest risk of being excluded or discriminated against (McClendon 2016; Distelhorst and Hou 2014). While this literature largely focuses on the distribution of resources by central governments across districts and counties, bureaucrats on the frontlines of service provision may be prone to similar dynamics.

Taste-based discrimination against ethnic and religious minorities is not the only source of discrimination that can arise in settings of weak accountability, however. A substantial body of research suggests that corruption by street-level bureaucrats disproportionately affects poor and uneducated citizens, because these citizens tend to be less knowledgeable about their rights and less able to pursue recourse through formal reporting channels (Fried, Lagunes and Venkataramani 2010; Robinson, Seim et al. 2018; Banerjee et al. 2018). Underlying these findings is the idea that citizen-bureaucrat interactions frequently entail a bargaining process in which citizens seek to access the services to which they're entitled while bureaucrats try to either shirk these obligations or solicit bribes.² In this interaction, citizens' bargaining power depends on their levels of wealth and education, because these factors determine whether they have the time, knowledge, and skills to pursue formal channels of accountability, such as contacting a higher-level manager or lodging a complaint with an official oversight body. Bureaucrats, for their part, can be expected to be strategic, exploiting poor and uneducated complainants who lack the skills to hold them accountable, while holding off on such behavior when interacting with those can.

Implicit in this framework — and indeed, in much of the literature on bureaucratic discrimination — is the assumption that higher-level officials would like to ensure that agency rules and guidelines are adhered to, but are prevented from doing so by the difficulties they face when trying to monitor their staff. However, in many weak states, power is organized according to a personalistic or “patrimonial” logic grounded in patronage, clientelism, and solidarity among networks of

²See Banerjee, Mullainathan and Hanna (2013) for a more formal treatment of this framework.

elites (Lemarchand 1972; Bratton and Van de Walle 1994). In these systems, the offices of the state are often treated as “benefices” by officeholders who make little distinction between public and private spheres and hold little regard for the public interest (Hyden 2012, 96). Because appointments are made on the basis of loyalty rather than merit (Pitcher, Moran and Johnston 2009), officeholders tend to lack commitment to the public interest, and may instead be beholden to patrons higher up the chain of command. To maintain relations with their patrons, and to expand their own base of supporters, officeholders face constant pressure to divert public resources towards “bestowals of favor” and acts of reciprocity to those to whom they’re indebted (Weber 1978, 958).

When power is organized in this way, ordinary citizens are likely to find that their ability to exercise formal channels of accountability is irrelevant when negotiating with bureaucrats, because their complaints will only be ignored by supervisors who hold little regard for the public interest. Instead, they may find that the most effective strategy when trying to access services from frontline bureaucrats is to leverage their connections to political elites. From an equity standpoint, patrimonial forms of authority imply that those without connections to political elites will be at a disadvantage when accessing services from the state, regardless of their wealth or education.

PREDICTIONS

The above discussion points to three potential power arrangements that could give rise to police discrimination, each with a distinct set of predictions. The first occurs when rank-and-file officers operate within the confines of agency rules and guidelines, but perform work that is inherently autonomous and discretionary in nature. Under these conditions, individual officers may exhibit “taste-based” discrimination against minorities or socially marginalized groups, but we would not necessarily expect them to discriminate against those who lack the skills to hold them accountable — i.e. those who are poor or lack education — because their actions remain within the scope of their authority under agency rules and guidelines.

The second occurs when high-ranking officials and police commanders would like to ensure policing services are delivered professionally, impartially, and in accordance with the law, but are

prevented from doing so by monitoring problems that enable rank-and-file officers to violate these standards. Under these conditions, officers can be expected to discriminate against those least able to alert their supervisors through formal channels of accountability — such as those with limited education or income — exploiting their lack of bargaining power as an opportunity to shirk, solicit bribes, or otherwise neglect their duties. We therefore expect members of these groups to be less likely to report crimes, and when they do report, to be less satisfied with the police and to experience less successful case outcomes.

The final arrangement that can lead to bias occurs when power is organized in a patrimonial manner, with police officials and commanders owing their positions of authority not to merit or qualification, but to their connections to other elites. Under these conditions, citizens' bargaining power vis a vi bureaucrats is likely to be determined less by their ability to exercise formal avenues of accountability than by their ability to leverage their relationships with government elites. These elites can solicit the help of their colleagues in the police force to pressure rank-and-file officers to perform, or they can intervene directly, demanding performance while signaling their ability to contact higher-level authorities if necessary. As a result of these dynamics, we expect officers to improve on their otherwise lackluster performance when interacting with politically connected individuals, exerting greater effort, soliciting fewer informal fees, and ultimately delivering higher-quality service.

REASONS FOR OPTIMISM?

While the literature on public bureaucracies provides reasons to expect discrimination against poor, uneducated, minority, and politically-unconnected citizens, there are also reasons to be more optimistic. For one, the principle that all citizens are equal before the law is universally recognized as among the core obligations of the state, and many government agencies devote considerable attention to the importance of objectivity and impersonality in the provision of services when training bureaucrats.³ This is particularly true in the criminal justice sector, and in developing countries

³See for instance, Article 26 of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR), adopted by the UN General Assembly on December 16, 1966; and the International Declaration of Human Rights, adopted by the UN

that receive training and assistance from international organizations such as the United Nations (Malan 2008). With so much attention given to equality before the law, police may have come to internalize this principle as a norm, integrating it into what it means to be a professional and committing to serve all citizens equally, despite whatever biases they may hold in private.

Second, where minorities and socially disadvantaged groups constitute important voting blocks, politicians may have strong political incentives to prevent discrimination by street-level bureaucrats. Indeed, research has shown that political incentives can be a powerful driver of service delivery generally and towards the poor in particular, even in countries with limited capacity to overcome the principal-agent problems that can arise between politicians and bureaucrats (Ross 2006; Kudamatsu 2012). If political incentives can improve the quality and quantity of services, then it stands to reason they may also help to minimize potential biases against politically important groups.

A final factor that may mitigate the potential for bureaucratic discrimination is that many governments have made efforts to ensure bureaucratic institutions are representative of the population they serve, at times going so far as to implement ethnic, gender, or location-based quota systems (Bird 2014). Such policies may mitigate discrimination by increasing descriptive representation within bureaucracies (Meier, Wrinkle and Polinard 1999); by increasing contact between majority group bureaucrats and minorities (Allport, Clark and Pettigrew 1954); or by increasing the degree to which bureaucrats empathize with those they serve on the basis of their shared experiences.

3 SETTING

Monrovia is the capital city of Liberia, a small West Africa nation of approximately 4 million people. Since the end of Liberia's civil war in 2003, Monrovia's population has grown to an estimated 2 million, up from 200,000 in 1984, before the war began.⁴ The majority of Monrovia's

General Assembly on December 10, 1946.

⁴Population is from the Liberian Institute for Statistics and Geo-Information Services (LISGIS), projected from the 2008 Census.

residents are poor and live in densely-populated, informal settlements, though the city is also home to a class of political elites and a small but growing middle class. Data collected for this study suggests that 60% live on less than \$2 day, 82% are either unemployed or work in the informal economy, and 55% have less than a high school education.

People from each of Liberia's 13 official ethnic groups can be found in Monrovia, and in roughly equal proportion to their share of the country as a whole. With the exception of Liberia's Christian/Muslim divide, ethnic divisions are not an especially prominent feature of residents' everyday lives. Inter-marriage is common, and most communities are highly heterogeneous, though it is not uncommon to find neighborhoods within communities where the majority of inhabitants are from a single ethnic group.

Crime is a major problem in Monrovia. According to Afrobarometer data collected in 2016, 65 percent of the city's residents reported that they or someone they knew was a victim of theft in the past year, 35 percent reported that they or someone they knew was physically assaulted, and 78 percent reported they felt unsafe in their neighborhood "several times", "many times", or "always." These figures are the highest of any of the 36 capital cities covered by Afrobarometer's Round 6 Survey.

In addition to its problem with crime, Monrovia has many of the characteristics that previous research suggests would lead to police discrimination. Much like the LNP as a whole, the Monrovia division of the LNP is notoriously under-resourced, with most stations lacking essential tools such as vehicles, radios, handcuffs, electricity, and even stationary (Baker 2010). To fund their services, many stations have resorted to "fee-for-service" models of service delivery. This has led to complaints that victims face "a bewildering array of fees" when reporting crimes, including "registration fees, gas money for police investigators, requirements that victims pay the cost of food for the detained accused, lawyers' fees, bribes, and indirect costs such as money for transportation and time spent away from livelihoods" (Isser, Lubkemann and N'Tow 2009, 3).

Mechanisms to hold police accountable are also lacking. At the station level, Commanders are notorious for failing to adequately monitor their subordinates (Human Rights Watch, 2013).

Absenteeism is pervasive, and the practice of “reassigning oneself” to a more profitable post (e.g. in the traffic sector) is not uncommon. While the LNP has taken strides to address these problems in recent years, most notably by establishing the Professional Standards Division for handling complaints of police misconduct, progress on the ground remains limited (Downie 2013).

These dynamics have led to serious concerns about the impartiality of the LNP. In 2006, the International Crisis Group observed that “there is a crisis of confidence in the Liberian police and justice system because powerful individuals have used it as a political tool through which to exercise and legitimise their power” (International Crisis Group 2006, 2). By 2009, most residents had come to view the police as little more than “a forum in which wealthy, powerful, and socially connected people assert their will” (Isser, Lubkemann and N’Tow 2009, 11). And in 2013, a report by Human Rights Watch reached a similar conclusion, reporting that “police corruption denies ordinary Liberians their basic rights to personal security and redress,” and that “institutional neglect has led to the credible perception among many Liberians that wealth, not guilt, determines the outcome of a criminal case” (Human Rights Watch 2013).

Though observers have largely focused on the potential for discrimination against the poor and “those living on the margins” of society, the culture of impunity that pervades the LNP also raises the risk that certain ethnic or religious groups will face discrimination. In Liberia, many citizens perceive Muslims from the Mandingo, Vai, and Mende ethnic groups as “foreigners” from Guinea and Sierra Leone, despite the fact that their ancestors emigrated as early as the 18th century (Beleky 1973). Muslims from the Mandingo tribe, in particular, have long faced resentment for using political alliances to establish commercial privileges and secure land at the expense of ‘native’ tribes (Ellis 2001, 38). During Liberia’s civil war, divisions between Mandingos and predominantly Christian ethnic groups escalated into some of the war’s worst atrocities (Ellis 2001). Although Liberia has made progress towards reconciling the divide between Christians and Muslims in recent years, these divisions remain salient today, and there is at least some evidence that they contribute to patterns of biased policing. A recent study by Blair et al. (2018), for example, uses lab-in-the-field experiments implemented with teams of officers from the LNP to argue that

police discriminate against Muslim minorities when investigating crimes. Whether these patterns obtain outside the context of their experiments, however, remains an open question.

Liberia is also a country with a long history of patrimonialism in government, with appointments more often made on the basis of political criteria or personal connections rather than on competence for the job. Ellis (2001) describes patterns of state administration in twentieth century Liberia as a system in which “the use of official procedure for personal purposes operated at every level of administration,” from presidential officials and cabinet members to rank-and-file staff (Ellis 2001, 61). In this system, those in government would derive their position from their relationships with those above them, and would in turn use their position to enhance their social and political standing, dispensing patronage to their own set of clients, kin, and retainers.

This patronage-based system of governance has been emulated by subsequent governments and persists today, more than a decade after the civil war has ended (Reno 1995; Utas 2012). Observers have been particularly critical of the government’s failure to implement reforms that would centralize authority over recruitment and dismissal practices under the Civil Services Agency. The current system, which the International Crisis Group describes as fragmented, vulnerable to corruption, and plagued by “personalized politics” (ICG 2011, 17), is believed to reinforce the personalized nature of Liberia’s bureaucratic state because it indentures bureaucrats to patrons higher up the chain of command while also allowing them to build-out patronage networks of their own. The result, as Käihkö (2012, 188) describes, is that “patrons hold positions at every level of the state, from the presidency to the lowest public servant, and use the salaries and benefits they gain to feed their networks.” Ordinary citizens, for their part, rely on patrons in government for advice, jobs, and social support, as well as to facilitate their interactions with the state. While this reliance on elite patrons has its origins in traditional notions of dependency and reciprocity in rural Liberia (Ellis 2001), its operation within Liberia’s contemporary bureaucratic state has contributed to the blurring of the distinction between the public and private spheres and led to allegations of favoritism towards those with connections to elites in government (Kaufmann 2013, 164). The practice of calling on political elites to intervene on one’s behalf is particularly common in the

domain of criminal justice, where there is “a strong perception among many Liberians that the wealthy and the powerful are increasingly able to exercise undue influence” (Isser, Lubkemann and N’Tow 2009, 24).

4 RESEARCH DESIGN

My research design centers on two sources of data. The first is a conjoint survey experiment designed to measure citizens’ expectations of police discrimination. In the experiment, respondents were presented with a vignette about an individual who was victimized by crime and reported their case to the police. After being read the vignette, respondents were asked a series of questions about how they expected the police to handle the case, including whether they thought the police would take the case seriously, treat the victim with respect, and go through the effort to visit the crime scene, among other questions. Respondents repeated this exercise twice; in each scenario, the attributes of the victim were randomly varied along four dimensions — religion, education, class, and political connections — while the type of crime was randomly varied along three levels of severity — a stolen phone, a nighttime burglary, and a nighttime burglary leading to aggravated assault with a cutlass. Further details on the experiment and its analysis are provided below.

The conjoint experiment is motivated by the idea that since citizens’ are the ones who most often interact with the police, they are best-positioned to report on whatever biases the police may hold. Thus, a correspondence between their expectations and the hypotheses developed above may be viewed as support for those hypotheses, while a lack of correspondence may be viewed as evidence against them.

Of course, citizens may be subject to biases of their own. Indeed, research shows that negative experiences tend to have an outsized influence on citizens’ perceptions of police (Brunson 2007), and that citizens tend to overestimate the prevalence of crime (Esberg and Mummolo 2018). More broadly, a large literature documents the prevalence of misperceptions among the masses (Bartels 2002; Nyhan and Reifler 2010; Campbell et al. 1960), raising the possibility that

expectations bear little resemblance to reality.

This possibility motivates the second component of my research design, which tests for police discrimination against victims of crime in the real-world using survey data from a crime victimization module that preceded the conjoint experiment. This analysis comes with its own set of assumptions and limitations, as I discuss below, but ones which are altogether distinct from those underlying the experimental analysis. Thus, I interpret a correspondence across the two analyses with respect to a particular hypothesis as a reliable test. Less obvious is how to handle cases in which there is not a correspondence. I return to this issue in the Discussion.

Tests of bureaucratic discrimination in the real-world have typically employed either of two research designs. The first involves running an audit-style experiment in which confederates with different socio-economic or racial attributes solicit information or services from government, and the frequency and quality of responses serve as the main outcome measures.⁵ While these designs offer a high degree of internal validity and are well-suited for measuring ‘point of contact’ forms of discrimination, they are generally ill-suited for measuring more complex forms of discrimination that arise during the course of service delivery, after the initial point of contact. For instance, it would be unfeasible — not to mention illegal and unethical — to try to use this approach to measure discrimination during the course of a police investigation, as this would require a very elaborate deception scheme.⁶

The second approach — and the one employed in this paper — is to use observational data to compare outcomes across potentially advantaged and disadvantaged groups after controlling for as many confounding factors as possible. A recent study uses this approach to test for discrimination against African Americans in the use of force by the police, comparing differences in likelihood that force is used after controlling for encounter and neighborhood characteristics (Fryer Jr 2019). This approach relies on the crucial assumption that unexplained variation in out-

⁵In political science, scholars have used this approach to measure discrimination by local election officials (White, Nathan and Faller 2015), legislators (Butler and Broockman 2011), and police at traffic checkpoints (Robinson, Seim et al. 2018; Fried, Lagunes and Venkataramani 2010), among others.

⁶Though see Blair et al. (2018) for an example of how lab-in-the-field experiments conducted with individual officers can be used to test for bias in the profiling of suspects.

comes across groups reflects discrimination, rather than confounding due to unobserved factors. Because this assumption is only plausible when a large number of factors are accounted for, this approach requires especially rich data.

Unfortunately, detailed data on crime reporting, case outcomes, and complainant characteristics is scarce, especially in weak and fragile states.⁷ To address this gap, I oversaw the administration of a crime victimization survey to a representative sample of 1800 adult residents of Monrovia, Liberia in July, 2017 and again in February 2019.⁸ The resulting data set includes 2570 incidents of crime and includes information on crime reporting, complainant satisfaction, case outcomes, and a large set of potentially confounding factors.

While my reliance on survey data allows me to conduct quantitative analyses of police effort and case outcomes that would otherwise not be possible, this approach is not without limitations. One key limitation is that responses may be subject to recall bias, social desirability bias, or other forms of bias that lead to inaccurate data. It is also possible that respondents interpret questions in different ways, especially when posed subjective questions such as “During the course of this investigation, were you treated with respect?” Moreover, there is no guarantee that these differences do not correlate with class, education religion, or political-connectedness, thereby biasing my results. I attempt to mitigate these biases by focusing on questions that were pretested extensively to ensure that respondents understood them accurately and consistently; by complementing subjective measures with more objective outcomes such as “during the course of the investigation, did the police ever visit the scene of the crime to investigate?”; and by conducting a placebo test to show that social desirability bias is unlikely to vary by class, education religion, or political-connectedness (see Section 6.4). Nevertheless, my results should be interpreted with the limitations of survey-based measures in mind.

In what follows, I describe the sample, experimental data, and observational data in greater detail. I then outline my construction of key variables and explicate the strategies I employ to

⁷Indeed, to the best of my knowledge, researchers have not yet collected or analyzed this type of fine-grained data to test for evidence of police discrimination in a developing-country setting.

⁸The survey is a panel at the community-level but not at the individual-level: the same communities were visited in 2017 and 2019, but respondents were sampled independently for each survey. For further details, see 4.1.

mitigate the risk of confounding factors.

4.1 SAMPLE

I employ observational and experimental survey data collected from 98 communities in Monrovia, Liberia. The data were collected in July 2017 and February 2019 as part of the baseline and endline surveys for an experimental evaluation of the LNP's community policing program.⁹ The sample includes 35 communities nominated by the police for inclusion in the evaluation, as well as 63 communities selected at random from the remaining communities within Monrovia.¹⁰ Within each community, 20 adult residents were selected to participate in the survey independently at baseline and endline via a random-walk procedure, resulting in a total sample size of 3920 respondents. Collectively, these respondents reported on 2570 crimes against either themselves or a member of their immediate family.

4.2 DATA AND MEASUREMENT

4.2.1 CONJOINT EXPERIMENT

The conjoint experiment was included in the 2019 survey only. Respondents were presented with a vignette in which the victim's attributes were randomly varied along the dimensions listed in Table 1. An example of one of the vignettes is as follows:¹¹

Let's say that during the rainy season, a man named [Christian / Muslim name] had his phone stolen near his home in [Muslim / Christian town name]. After the incident, a neighbor came to [name] with information about who may have committed the crime and recommended he report the case to the police for further investigation.

At first, [name] was scared to take the case to the police [because he is poor]. He [also is not a book person and doesn't know much about the law], and [because he just recently moved to Monrovia, he doesn't know any big big people in government who

⁹Results from the evaluation are not included in this study but can be found in Morse (2019). Further details on the experimental study are available at: <http://egap.org/registration/5472>.

¹⁰The sampling frame for this study was provided by the Liberia Institute of Statistics and Geo-Information Services (LISGIS).

¹¹The full set of vignettes is presented in the Appendix.

can give him advice]. However, after a few days [name] was able to put his worries aside and decided take time off from his work as a [market vendor] to report the theft to the police.

Table 1: Crime Victim Attributes Randomized in Conjoint Experiment

Attribute	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Religion	Christian	Muslim	NA
Class	Poor (Market vendor)	Rich (NGO job)	NA
Related to govt official	No	Yes (Uncle)	NA
Education	Illiterate	Literate	NA
Crime	Theft of phone	Burglary	Burglary, assault

After listening to the vignette, respondents were asked to rate on a four point scale how likely they think the victim would be to be satisfied with the police’s handling of the case, as well as how likely they think the police would be to: i) behave professionally, ii) treat the victim with respect, iii) investigate aggressively, iv) visit the crime scene, v) interview witnesses, and vi) solicit a bribe or “case registration” fee. I construct a composite index by summing all 7 variables,¹² then rescaling so the index has a mean of zero and a standard deviation of one. I also report results on each of the component variables, coded as indicators for “Likely” or “Very likely” responses. Table 2 provides descriptive statistics for the outcomes from the vignette experiment.

Table 2: Summary of outcomes in vignette experiment

% of responses “Likely” or “Very likely”	
Victim will be satisfied?	68%
Police will be professional?	76%
Police will be respectful?	79%
Police will investigate aggressively?	55%
Police will visit crime scene?	82%
Police will interview witnesses?	81%
Police will solicit bribe or fee?	69%

Notes: N = 3788 vignettes.

¹²I recode responses to the question on bribery so that higher values correspond to a lower expected likelihood of bribery.

4.2.2 OBSERVATIONAL DATA

The crime victimization survey collected information about eight categories of crime: armed robbery, burglary, simple assault, aggravated assault, sexual violence, domestic violence, verbal domestic abuse, and property encroachment. Respondents were asked whether they or a member of their household was a victim of any of these types of crime in the past 6 months, and if so, whether the incident was reported to the police, courts, or local leaders. For each crime that was reported to one of these authorities, respondents were asked a set of follow-up questions about how their case was handled, including whether they had to pay informal fees, whether they felt they were respected and treated fairly, and, for cases reported to the police, whether the police interviewed witnesses, took written testimony, or visited the crime scene.

The resulting dataset provides incident-level data on 2,570 incidents of crime, 496 of which were reported to the police, 291 of which were reported to local leaders, and 84 of which were taken to court (Table 3).¹³ Because the sample of court cases is too small for multivariate analysis, this paper focuses only on cases reported to the police and local leaders.

CASE-LEVEL OUTCOMES

Respondents who reported their case to the police were asked a set of questions about their satisfaction with how the police handled the case, including whether they felt the police i) treated them with respect, ii) took their case seriously, iii) were fair to both sides, iv) were available and accessible during the investigation, and v) whether they would report a similar case to the police in the future. For each of these questions, I code an indicator variable taking a value of 1 for an affirmative response. I analyze these outcomes individually and, to mitigate concerns about multiple hypothesis testing, as a single *subjective satisfaction index* constructed as the standardized average across all five individual outcomes.

I complement these subjective measures of police performance with a set of more objective

¹³On average, respondents reported that they or a member of their family was a victim of .67 crimes in the past six months.

Table 3: What types of crimes are most common and where are they reported?

	# of cases (out of 2570)	
Type of crime:		
Burglary	39%	1004
Simple assault	12%	307
Aggravated assault	10%	251
Property Encroachment	10%	253
Armed robbery	8%	201
Domestic abuse (verbal)	5%	115
Domestic violence	3%	92
Sexual violence	1%	23
Other	4%	84
Crime reported to:		
Police	19%	496
Court	3%	84
Local leaders	11%	291
Nowhere	67%	1729

outcomes drawn from questions about concrete, effortful actions the police may have taken while trying to address the case, including whether the police i) solicited a bribe, ii) visited the crime scene, or iii) interviewed witnesses; in addition, I consider whether the perpetrator was “brought to justice” and whether the case was ultimately “resolved” from the perspective of the respondent. Responses to each of these questions are coded as indicator variables denoting affirmative responses. Finally, I aggregate these variables additively into a single, standardized *police performance index*.¹⁴

SOURCES OF DISCRIMINATION

In Section 2, I identified three groups of citizens at risk of police discrimination — Muslims, the poor, and those with limited education — as well as one group of citizens who may benefit from favoritism, namely those with personal connections to elites in government. I measure each of

¹⁴Soliciting a bribe is reverse coded when constructing the *police performance index*, such that 1 indicates that the police did *not* solicit a bribe.

these characteristics using responses from the survey. For ease of presentation and interpretation, I measure income and education on a binary scale using indicator variables that take a value of 1 for any individual with below median household income or years of education, respectively.

My measure of personal connections to elites in government is based on the question “Are you related to any big big person in government?” In Liberia, this terminology is typically understood as referring to high-ranking officials such as legislators, ministers, deputy ministers, and senior staff. Though subject to some degree of ambiguity, pretesting revealed a surprising degree of consensus on who would qualify as a “bigman” in government, even among those with limited education and little understanding of government. During focus groups in slum communities, for instance, participants repeatedly and independently cited being issued a government car as the key indicator of whether one qualifies as “bigman” — a distinction which, according to the guidelines of Liberia’s General Services Agency, is typically restricted to legislators, ministers, deputy ministers, and selected senior staff.

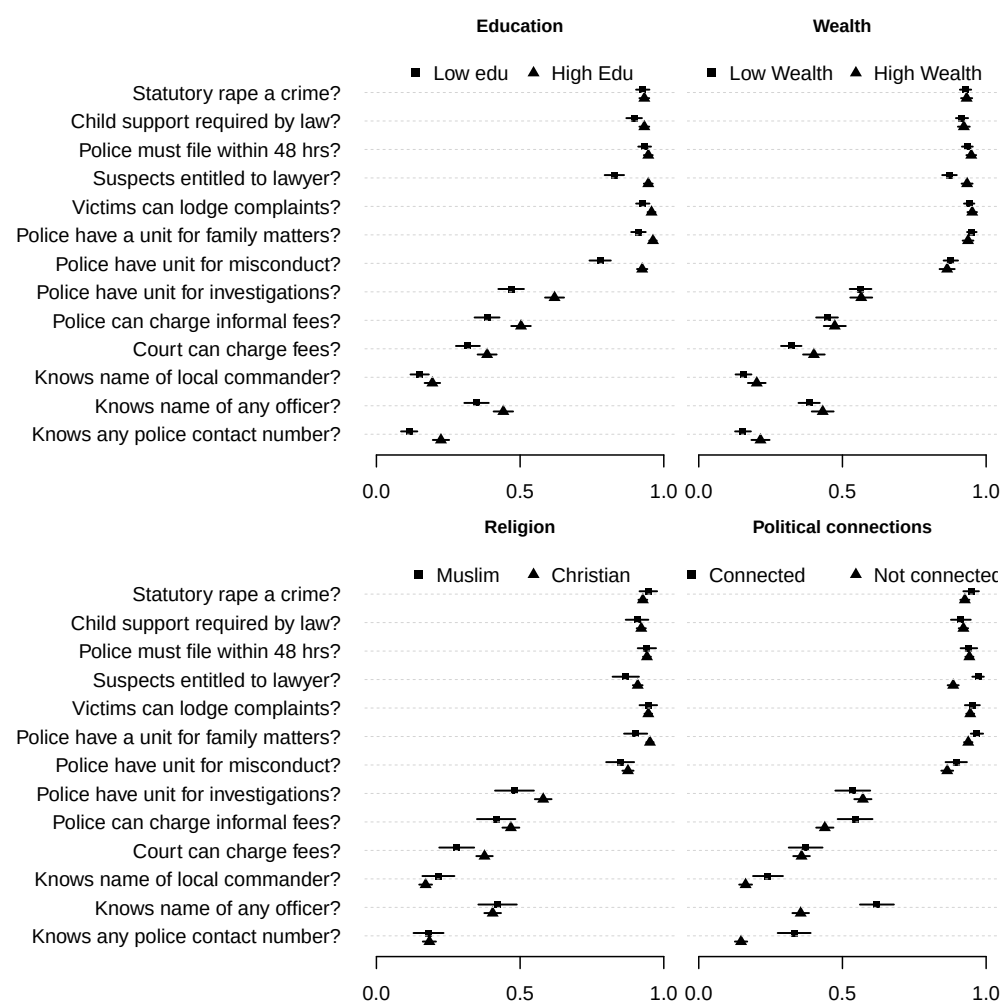
Among the sample of crime victims, 16% are Muslim, 40% have below median education,¹⁵ 51% have below median wealth, and 20% are related to a high-level official in government. Notably, being related to a high-level official in government does not associate with wealth, education, or religion, and is only weakly associated with ethnicity.¹⁶ While the absence of a strong association between political connections and ethnicity may seem at odds with much of the literature on patrimonial governance and ethnic politics, it is consistent with prevailing power arrangements in Liberia — because Liberia’s population is roughly equally divided across its thirteen officially-recognized ethnic groups, no one group dominates its political institutions. Indeed, Liberia’s postwar government campaigned on a platform of ethnic reconciliation and inclusion, and has subsequently been praised for following through on this commitment with the creation of a government that is broadly representative of the country’s ethnic, religious, and regional diversity (ICG 2011).

¹⁵Below median education includes anyone with less than a high school education.

¹⁶A detailed comparison of politically connected individuals to those without connections is presented in the Appendix.

A key assumption underlying the theoretical motivation for this study is that knowledge of the criminal justice system and police accountability channels — and thus bargaining power when interacting with the police — is lower among individuals with limited education. Figure 1 tests this proposition by showing how knowledge varies by level of education, wealth, religion, and political connectedness. While there is little difference across religion, wealth, or political connectedness, there is a large difference in knowledge among those with below versus above-median education. These individuals are ten percentage points less likely to know about the Professional Standards Division of the LNP, eight percentage points less likely to know that it is illegal for police to charge informal fees, five percentage points less likely to know that it is illegal for Judges to charge informal fees, and six percentage points less likely to know the contact number of the police. These results suggest that those with limited education are indeed at a disadvantage when interacting with the police.

Figure 1: Knowledge gaps by education, wealth, religion, and political connections



Notes: Differences in knowledge of the law and police accountability channels by education, wealth, religion, and political connectedness. The X-axis displays the percentage of correct responses for each group.

5 EMPIRICAL STRATEGY

ANALYSIS OF EXPERIMENTAL DATA

Following the approach outlined in Hainmueller, Hopkins and Yamamoto (2014), I estimate the change in expected police performance associated with each of the four victim-level attributes via:

$$y_{ik} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Muslim_{ik} + \beta_2 Poor_{ik} + \beta_3 Illiterate_{ik} + \beta_4 Connected_{ik} + e_{ik} \quad (1)$$

where $i \in \{1, 2, \dots, 1895\}$ denotes the respondent and $k \in \{1, 2\}$ denotes the round.¹⁷

The outcome is the composite index of expected police performance or one of its six component variables, and the explanatory variables correspond to each of the randomly varied attributes.

ANALYSIS OF CRIME-LEVEL DATA

Applied to crime-level data on reporting and complainant satisfaction, theories of bureaucratic discrimination predict that the police will be more likely to shirk, solicit bribes, or otherwise fail to seriously investigate cases brought to them by Muslims, the poor, and those with limited education. As a result, we expect members of these groups to be: i) less satisfied with how the police handle their cases, ii) less likely to experience successful case outcomes, and iii) less likely to report crimes to the police in the first place.

I test these predictions using a simple OLS regression model of the following form:

$$y_{civs} = \beta_1 Muslim_i + \beta_2 Low_Income_i + \beta_3 Low_Edu_i + \beta_4 Connected_i + \alpha + \mathbf{X}_{civ}\theta + e_{civ} \quad (2)$$

¹⁷ $N = 1895$ corresponds to the number of survey respondents in the February 2019 survey. Since each respondent reported their expectations for two vignettes, $N \approx 3790$ in the analysis.

where y_{civ} is a measure of reporting or police performance for crime c against individual i in community v , $\mathbf{X}_{civ}$ denotes observable control variables, and e_{civ} captures all other, unobserved factors that may explain variation in reporting or police performance. If discrimination exists, then we would expect to observe a negative coefficient on *Muslim*, *Low_Income*, and/or *Low_Education*, or a positive coefficient on *Politically_Connected*, even after controlling the variables captured by $\mathbf{X}_{civ}$, which include: type of crime, month the crime occurred, nearest police station, whether the identify of the alleged perpetrator was known at the time of the crime, and the age, gender, ethnicity, household size, and community of residence of the victim.¹⁸

In this type of discrimination analysis, there is always the concern that there may be some unobserved factor other than discrimination that explains the presence of religious or class-based differences and is not accounted for by observed control variables. For instance, it is possible that poor individuals tend to live in communities where it is inherently difficult to investigate crimes due to mistrust of the police and low community cooperation. Recognizing these challenges, police may reason that it is not worthwhile to expend effort investigating crimes that come from these communities. While the inclusion of community fixed-effects guards against this particular type of confounding, it is always possible that other, unobserved sources of confounding are not accounted for.

One way to gauge whether unobserved factors are likely to confound is to assess how our estimated differences change as more controls are added. If differences estimated from a “naive” regression model without control variables become small and insignificant once controls ($\mathbf{X}_{civ}$) are added, then this is evidence that religious or class-based differences in performance and satisfaction are explained by differences in the type or nature of crimes that are reported, rather than discrimination. By extension, it also suggests that accounting for additional, unobserved factors would likely serve to further attenuate racial and class-based differences. Conversely, if differences estimated from a naive regression model remain large and statistically significant even after

¹⁸Technically I measure these variables for the *respondent* rather than the actual *victim*, the victimization module did not distinguish between crimes against the respondent and crimes against members of their household. However, apart from age and gender, these variables should be the same for both the victim and the respondent.

controlling for a robust set of potential confounders, then this would constitute evidence of discrimination. Finally, if differences are null in both the naive and fully controlled models, then this constitutes compelling evidence *against* discrimination, for it suggests that differences in the characteristics of crimes that are reported, whether observed or unobserved, are not confounding.

6 RESULTS

6.1 GENERAL PATTERNS OF CRIME, CRIME REPORTING, AND POLICE PERFORMANCE

Before turning to the question of whether the police discriminate against certain groups, I consider general patterns of crime, crime reporting, and police performance when investigating crimes. The first observation of note in this regard is that crime is quite common, with 41% of respondents reporting that they or a member of their immediate family were victims of crime in the past year.¹⁹ As shown in Table 3, the most common type of crime was burglary, which accounted for 39% of all incidents, followed by simple assault (12%), aggravated assault (10%), property disputes (10%), and armed robbery (8%). Perhaps surprisingly, given the amount of attention paid to issues of sexual and gender based violence in Liberia (Bacon 2015), domestic and sexual violence were relatively rare, with only 3% of respondents reporting this type of victimization.²⁰

A second pattern evident from Table 3 is that only a fraction of crimes that occur — about 25% — are ever reported to the police. In part, this may reflect the fact that some crimes are simply not serious enough to justify the costs of reporting. Yet even for more serious crimes, such as aggravated assault or armed robbery, rates of reporting are low, at 29% and 38% percent respectively, suggesting that many citizens lack confidence in the ability of the police to effectively investigate crimes.

Table 4 summarizes this study's measures of the police's performance while investigating reported crimes ($N = 496$). The results paint a mixed but generally unfavorable picture of police performance. While 84 percent of complainants reported that the police were accessible and a similar percentage said they would report their case to the police again, 38 percent said the police

¹⁹Note that the analyses below are restricted to the selective sample of respondents from the representative survey who reported a crime.

²⁰It is, however, important to keep in mind that this may represent a lower bound on the incidence of these types of crimes, as male respondents may under report or simply be unaware of these kinds of victimizations among other members of their household.

were unfair in how they handled their case, 34 percent said they did not take their case seriously, and 27 percent said they failed to treat them with respect. In terms of effortful actions that the police might take to solve reported crimes, only 58 percent of complainants reported that the police visited the scene of the crime and only 53 percent reported that the police interviewed witnesses. More alarmingly, 46 percent of complainants reported having to pay informal fees, which on average totaled 9.8 USD, or roughly four days of income for the average Liberian.

Table 4: Summary of outcomes for those reporting crimes to the police

Complainant satisfaction outcomes	
Police treated you with respect?	73%
Police took your case seriously?	65%
Police fair to both sides?	62%
Police available and accessible?	84%
Would report your case to the police again?	79%
Police effort & case outcomes	
Had to pay the police?	46%
If had to pay: how much?	\$9.8
Police visited scene of crime?	58%
Police interviewed witnesses?	53%
Case was resolved?	52%

Notes: N=496 reported cases.

6.2 EXPERIMENTAL RESULTS ON CITIZENS' EXPECTATIONS OF POLICE DISCRIMINATION

Do expectations about police discrimination accord with the theories outlined in Section 2? Table 5 presents the results of the experiment respondents' expectations. Contrary to theories of "taste-based" discrimination against minorities, respondents do not expect Muslim victims to receive lower quality treatment when reporting crimes to the police. As shown Row 1 of the Upper and Lower panel of Table 5, the estimated effect of being a Muslim victim relative to being a Christian victim is close to zero and precisely estimated across all outcomes in the composite index.

The evidence on expected discrimination against the poor is mixed. On the one hand, respondents strongly associate being poor with lower police performance. When the victim is described as a "poor market vendor," respondents are 20 percentage points less likely to expect the police to be professional, 22 percentage points less likely to expect them to be respectful, 19 percentage points less likely to expect them to visit the crime scene, and 10 percentage points less likely to expect them to investigate the case aggressively, as compared to when victims are described as "having plenty money from their NGO job." But they are also eight percentage points less likely to expect the police to solicit a bribe or charge a "case registration" fee. While effect is of somewhat smaller magnitude than the others, it does suggest that lower overall expected police performance may be driven in part by the expectation that fewer resources will be available to support the investigation, consistent with the idea that respondents perceive petty bribes and informal fees to be a consequence of police lack of resources.

In terms of a "bargaining power" logic of discrimination against those with limited education, Table 5 shows that expected police performance is somewhat lower when the victim is described as someone who "is not a book person and doesn't know the law", as compared to when the victim is someone who "can read and write and knows the law very well." However, these effects are small in magnitude — just .02 standard deviations for the composite index — suggesting that illiteracy and lack of knowledge of the law is not perceived as an important vulnerability that

police exploit.

On the other hand, expectations of favoritism towards politically connected individuals are strong and consistent across most components of the composite index. When the victim is described as having “an uncle who is a bigman in the government” that they can turn to for advice, expected performance improves by .08 standard deviations in the composite index, as compared to victims who “just moved to Monrovia and don’t know any big big people in government who can give them advice.” This overall effect is driven by lower expected likelihood of being charged a bribe or informal fee, as well as greater expected professionalism, respectfulness, and effort to resolve the case.

Table 5: Average conditional marginal effects of attributes on expected performance indicators

	Composite index	Victim will be satisfied	Police will: be professional	Police will: be respectful
Muslim	-0.00 (0.01)	0.00 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.01)	-0.01 (0.01)
Poor	-0.10*** (0.01)	-0.10*** (0.01)	-0.20*** (0.01)	-0.22*** (0.01)
Illiterate	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.04* (0.02)	-0.05*** (0.01)	-0.03* (0.01)
Connected	0.08*** (0.01)	0.07*** (0.01)	0.14*** (0.01)	0.14*** (0.01)
Y mean	0.00	0.68	0.76	0.80
N	3788	3788	3788	3788
Police will:				
	investigate aggressively	visit crime scene	interview witnesses	charge fees
Muslim	0.02 (0.02)	0.01 (0.01)	0.02 (0.01)	-0.02 (0.02)
Poor	-0.10*** (0.02)	-0.19*** (0.01)	-0.07*** (0.01)	-0.08*** (0.02)
Illiterate	-0.01 (0.02)	-0.02+ (0.01)	-0.01 (0.01)	-0.01 (0.01)
Connected	0.02 (0.02)	0.11*** (0.01)	0.05*** (0.01)	-0.05** (0.02)
Y mean	0.56	0.82	0.82	0.69
N	3788	3788	3788	3788

Robust standard errors in parenthesis, clustered by respondent. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Composite index is standardized with mean 0 and standard deviation 1. All other outcomes are binary indicators for “Likely” or “Very Likely” response.

6.3 EVIDENCE OF POLICE DISCRIMINATION FROM CRIME-LEVEL DATA

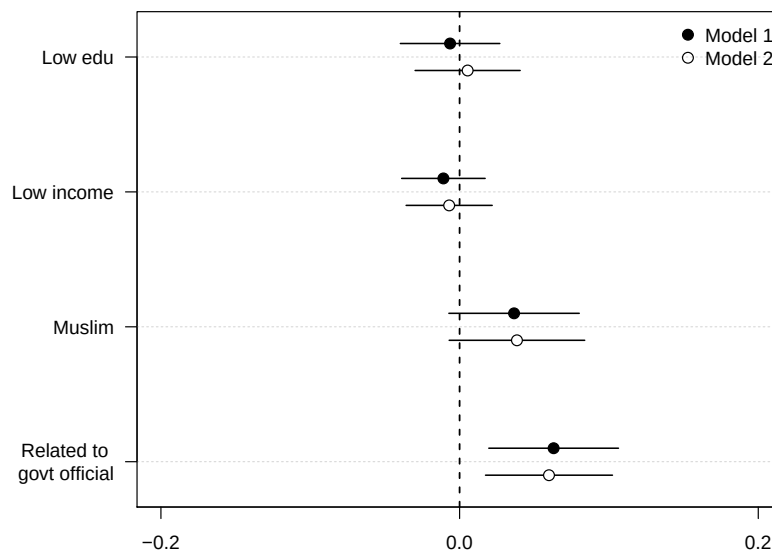
To what extent do these extent do citizens' expectations about police performance and discrimination discourage disadvantaged groups from reporting crimes to police? This section continues the investigation of police discrimination and its effects on access to justice with an analysis of crime-level data on crime reporting and complainant satisfaction.

Figure 2 reports how crime reporting varies by religion, class, education, and political connectedness. In contrast to theories predicting taste-based discrimination against religious minorities, Muslims are if anything slightly *more* likely to report crimes to the police than non-Muslims, with an estimated association of 4 percentage points ($p < 0.12$). Figure 2 also shows that victims with below median education or below median income are not significantly more or less likely to report crimes to the police than those above the median, contrary to theories predicting bias against poor and low-class individuals. Finally, Figure 2 shows that victims who are related to elites in government are about six percentage points more likely to report crimes to the police than those without such connections, consistent with the hypothesis that politically connected individuals are favored by the police.

There are, of course, many reasons unrelated to expected bias and discrimination that may explain these differences in reporting. As a more direct test of police discrimination, Figure 3 examines patterns of complainant satisfaction among those who actually reported their case to the police ($N=496$). The results provide little evidence of discrimination based on class, religion, or education. Complainants with below-median levels of education or income express roughly the same level of satisfaction with how the police handled their case as complainants with above-median education or income, while Muslims, for their part, express roughly the same level of satisfaction as non-Muslims. These null results are consistent across multiple measures and are robust to the inclusion of controls for complainant and crime-level characteristics, suggesting that differences in the nature of crimes reported are unlikely to account for these (null) results.

The results in Figure 3 do, however, support the hypothesis that the police favor politically

Figure 2: Differences in crime reporting by religion, income, education, and political-connections

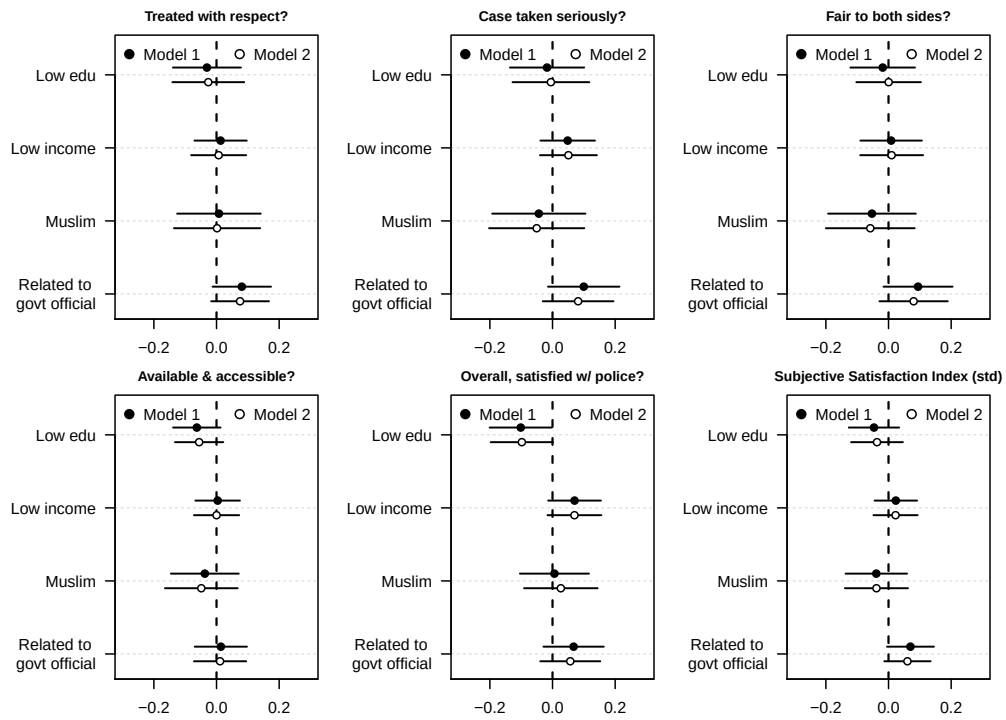


Notes: Differences in crime reporting by religion, income, education, and connections. Model 1 includes controls for type of crime only. Model 2 includes additional controls for crime location and complainant characteristics, following Equation 2 in Section 5. Standard errors clustered by community.

connected individuals. Compared to those without connections to political elites, complainants with connections are eight percentage points more likely to feel the police treated them with respect, eight percentage points more likely to feel the police were fair, nine percentage points more likely to feel their case was taken seriously, and four percentage points more likely to report that they were satisfied with the police's handling of their case. While not all of these differences reach conventional levels of significance, they are consistent in their direction across each of the individual measures and marginally significant in the aggregate index ($p < 0.11$).

Complainants' subjective evaluations of how they were treated by the police are important because they influence perceptions of police legitimacy and willingness to cooperate with the police (Tyler 2006; Levi, Sacks and Tyler 2009). However, subjective evaluations may or may not reflect more objective measures of police performance, such as whether cases are thoroughly investigated and resolved. Figure 4 complements the results reported in Figure 3 by reporting differences in objective measures of police effort and performance, including whether the complainant had to pay a bribe, whether the police investigated witnesses or visited the crime scene, whether

Figure 3: Differences in complainant satisfaction by religion, income, education, and political connections

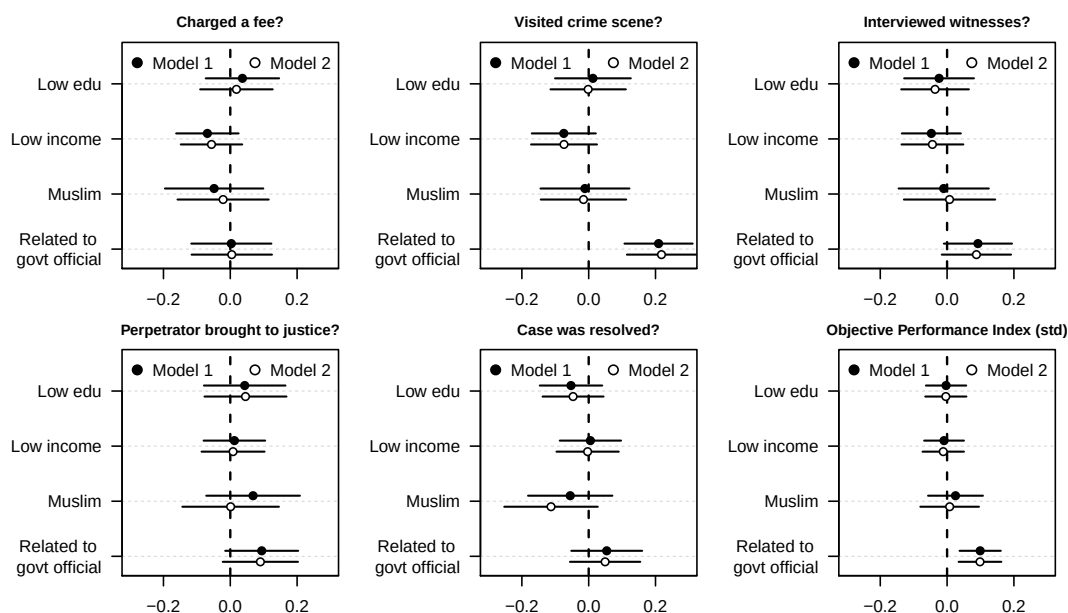


Notes: Differences in complainant satisfaction by religion, income, education, and political connections. Model 1 includes controls for type of crime only. Model 2 includes additional controls for crime location and complainant characteristics, following Equation 2 in Section 5. Standard errors clustered by community.

the perpetrator was brought to justice, and whether the incident was ultimately resolved.

The results again provide little evidence to suggest the police discriminate on the basis of religion, class, or education, with differences across these dimensions small and statistically insignificant across all measures and specifications. Politically connected individuals, on the other hand, appear to experience greater police effort and more successful case outcomes. As compared to individuals without connections, these individuals were twenty-two percentage points more likely to report that the police visited the crime scene, nine percentage points more likely to report that the police interviewed witnesses, and eight percentage points more likely to report that the perpetrator was brought to justice. Adding controls for complainant and crime-level factors does little to alter these differences.

Figure 4: Differences in case outcomes by religion, income, education, and political connections



Notes: Differences in case outcomes by religion, income, and education. Model 1 includes controls for type of crime only. Model 2 includes additional controls for crime location and complainant characteristics, following Equation 2 in Section 5. Standard errors clustered by community.

6.4 ROBUSTNESS OF CRIME-LEVEL RESULTS & CONSIDERATION OF ALTERNATIVE MECHANISMS

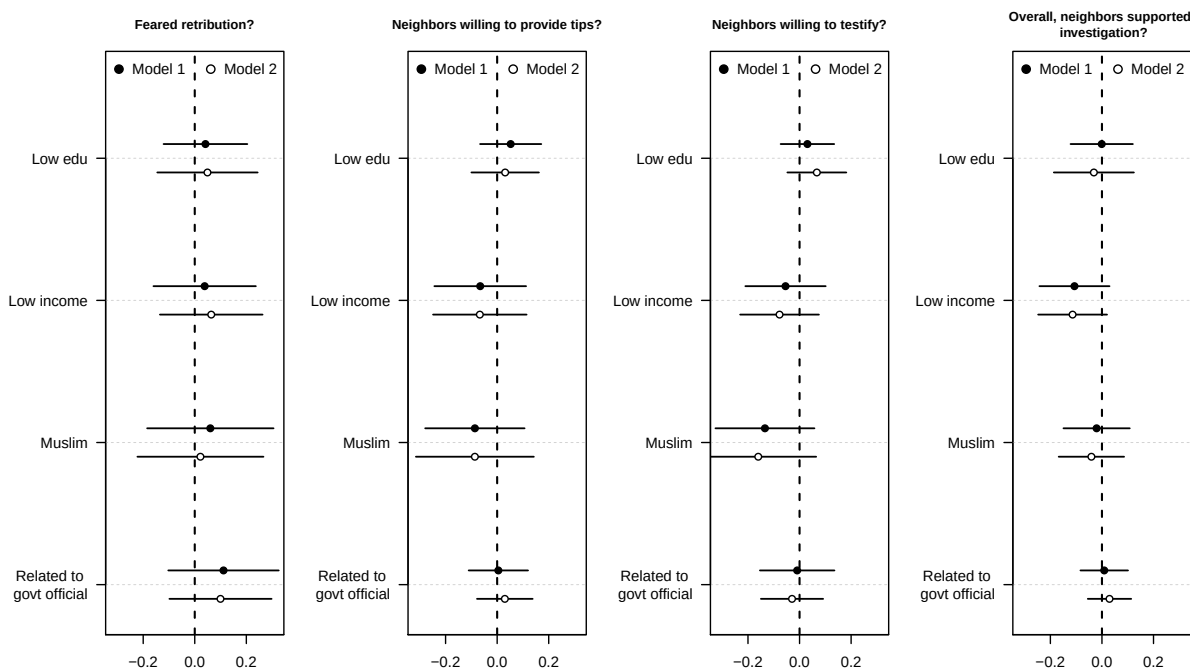
The crime-level data results presented above show that Muslims and individuals with below-median education or income are not significantly less likely to report crimes to the police, as compared to non-Muslims or individuals with above-median income or education, respectively. They further show that when these individuals do decide to report crimes to the police, they are not significantly less likely to be satisfied with how they were treated or to experience successful case outcomes. Individuals with connections to elites in government, on the other hand, are significantly more likely to report crimes to the police, as compared to individuals without these connections; moreover, when these individuals report crimes, they are significantly more likely to be satisfied with how they were treated and to experience successful case outcomes.

I interpret these patterns as evidence that the police favor politically connected individuals and evidence against the idea that the police discriminate against Muslims, the poor, or those with little education. However, as noted in Section 5, the validity of these interpretations rests on the assumption that unobserved factors associated with religion, education, income, or political connections do not also explain variation in reporting, satisfaction, or case outcomes. While it is impossible decisively rule out this possibility, I have attempted to limit the influence of confounders by controlling for a large set of observable complainant and crime-level characteristics, as outlined in Section 5. I have also shown that the results change little when moving from the sparse specification, which controls only for type of crime, to the full specification. This consistency indicates that observed factors are not confounding, and provides reason to believe that unobserved factors, insofar as they are similar in nature to observed factors, are also not confounding.

To further assess the possibility of unobserved confounding, this section identifies and evaluates the plausibility of four leading alternative explanations for my results. The first is the possibility that certain types of individuals tend to come from neighborhoods where crimes are easier to investigate, leading to greater investigative effort and more successful case outcomes. This sce-

nario could lead me to falsely conclude that politically connected people are favored by the police, or conversely, to falsely conclude that Muslim, poor, or uneducated complainants are not discriminated against (in the sense that easier investigations could ‘offset’ the negative effect on case outcomes due bias against these individuals). While the robustness of the results to community fixed-effects makes this explanation unlikely, it is possible that a similar type of dynamic plays out on a more local scale, across blocks or neighborhoods within a community. To assess this possibility, I draw on survey questions asking complainants whether their fellow community members i) supported the decision to involve the police, ii) were willing to give information to help the police solve the case, and iii) would have been willing to provide written testimony if asked to do so.

Figure 5: Differences in community cooperation by religion, income, education, and political-connections



Notes: Differences in community cooperation by religion, income, education, and political-connections. Model 1 includes controls for type of crime only. Model 2 includes additional controls following Equation 2 in Section 5. Standard errors clustered by community.

Figure 5 reports how these responses to these questions vary according to complainants’ religion, education, income, and political-connectedness. The results provide little evidence to

suggest that these characteristics predict community cooperation, with differences close to zero across all four questions pertaining to community cooperation.

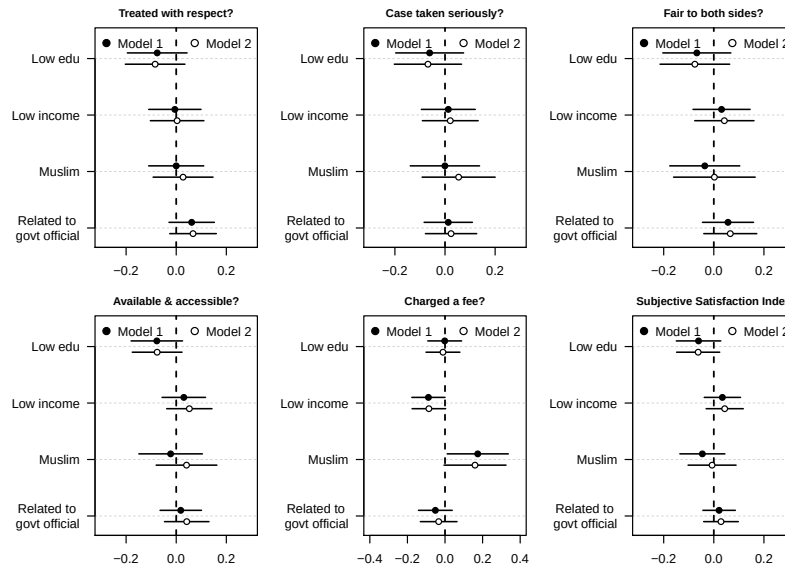
A second possibility is that some groups are simply more likely to offer socially desirable answers when asked questions about the police, calling into question the validity of this study's reliance on self-reported measures of police performance. To assess whether this is likely to be the case, I test for differences in respondents' perceptions of the police in general, outside the context of their personal experience when reporting a crime, on the assumption that biases leading to socially-desirable responses should manifest in these types of questions too. Examples of questions included in this placebo analysis include whether the police as a whole are trustworthy, whether the police "listen to the views of members of my community," and whether the police are corrupt, among others. To ensure this placebo analysis is not itself confounded by post-treatment bias among those reporting crimes to the police, I consider differences in perceptions among those who were never a victim of a crime ($N = 2189$) as well as those who were a victim of crime but did not report it to the police ($N = 1385$), in addition to differences among those who were a victim of a crime that was reported ($N = 392$). The results, reported in Appendix A.1, provide little evidence to suggest that social desirability bias influences the results. Across all three subgroups, differences in perceptions between Muslims and Christians, individuals with and without political connections, and individuals with above versus below median education are small and statistically insignificant. Although individuals with below median income are less likely to report favorable views of the police, this suggests that if anything, the null effects of low income on police performance are downward rather than upward biased.

A third possibility that could lead to confounding would arise if certain types of individuals are better at advocating for themselves when interacting with authorities, for reasons unrelated to their political capital, religion, education, or income. It is possible, for example, that politically connected families tend to be more cohesive and therefore devote greater effort and resources toward advocating for individual family members when they're in need. This scenario would lead us to falsely conclude that politically connected individuals are favored by the police, when in fact

they're simply better positioned to draw on the help of their fellow family members.

To assess this possibility, I consider patterns of satisfaction among those reporting crimes to local leaders ($N = 291$). In Liberia, local leaders often handle property disputes and misdemeanor offenses such as simple assault or petty theft. If politically connected individuals are better at negotiating with authorities for reasons other than their political connections, then they should also report greater satisfaction when reporting cases to local leaders. The results, reported in Figure 6, show that this is not the case. Politically connected are not significantly more or less likely to feel that they were treated with respect, that their case was taken seriously, that the leaders were fair to both sides, or that the leaders were available and accessible, as compared to individuals without connections. Nor were they significantly more or less likely to pay a bribe. These results suggest that there may be something uniquely political about the advantages that politically connected individuals enjoy when interacting with the police.

Figure 6: Differences in satisfaction with local leaders by religion, income, education, and political-connections



Notes: Differences in satisfaction by religion, income, education, and political-connections. Model 1 includes controls for type of crime only. Model 2 includes additional controls following Equation 2 in Section 5. Standard errors clustered by community.

The final alternative explanation considered here is that the apparent favoritism expressed

towards politically connected individuals reflects the fact that these individuals are especially likely to share ethnic ties with police officers. If this were true, and if officers have a tendency to favor their coethnics, then this could lead us to falsely attribute differences in performance to political dynamics rather than shared ethnicity. While plausible, this explanation seems unlikely given that political-connectedness is only weakly associated with ethnicity, as discussed in Section 5, and given that the results hold even when controlling for complainants' ethnicity.

7 DISCUSSION

The results of the crime-level analysis accord with the results of the experimental analysis on three of the four forms of discrimination considered in this study: taste-based discrimination against Muslims, opportunistic exploitation of uneducated victims who lack the requisite skills and knowledge to hold police accountable, and discrimination against those without connections to political elites. But there is a mismatch between the experimental data and the crime-level data with respect to discrimination against the poor. Whereas the crime-level data provides little to no evidence of discrimination, the experimental data reveals that respondents expect police performance to be much lower when victims are poor as compared to when they are wealthy, and that this is only partly attributable to the perception that wealthy victims are better able to pay the informal fees that police sometimes charge to fund investigations.

Why are citizens more pessimistic about discrimination against the poor than the crime-level data suggests is warranted? In this section, I explore whether the apparent mismatch between expectations and reality might be explained by the conflation of *disparate impact* with *disparate treatment* in regards to the fees that victims sometimes have to pay to the police. As discussed in Section 3, the prevalence of informal fees for police services is a salient and contentious issue in Liberia, with critics alleging abuse of power and police acknowledging the prevalence and illegality of this practice while simultaneously justifying it as an unavoidable consequence of their lack of resources. Notwithstanding the debate over its justification, few would disagree that the practice is

closely linked to the perception that “justice is not for the poor” in Liberia (Human Rights Watch 2013, 5).

In Table 6, I present the results of two tests of the hypothesis that the mismatch between expectations and reality is at least partly explained by the conflation of disparate impact with disparate treatment. The first is a test of whether expected discrimination against the poor is stronger or weaker among the subset of respondents who’ve actually reported a crime to the police. Since we know from the crime-level data that these respondents on average received equal treatment regardless of their socioeconomic status (albeit of potentially low quality), then we would expect *expected discrimination* against the poor to be *lower* among these respondents if their expectations duly reflect their experiences. Conversely, if expected discrimination against the poor is driven by the salience of the police’s “fee for service” model of service delivery, which although not disparately applied to the poor is easily construed as such by virtue of its disparate impact, then we would expect *expected discrimination* against the poor to be as strong or stronger among this population, since they will have had greater exposure to these practices. By the same logic, we would expect *expected discrimination* against the poor to be stronger among respondents who had previously reported a case to the police and been forced to pay a bribe or informal fee, relative to those who’ve not had these experiences.

Column 1 of Table 6 shows that the negative effect of the victim in the vignette being poor as opposed to wealthy on expected police performance is slightly *stronger* among respondents who had previously reported a case to the police in the past 6 months. Although the interaction effect is not statistically significant, its direction is consistent with the idea that reporting crimes to the police heightens the salience of informal fees, which in turn becomes interpreted as disparate treatment or bias against the poor. Column 2 of Table 6 provides further evidence in support of this hypothesis, showing that the negative effect of the victim being poor is about 70 percent larger among those who previously reported a case to the police and were asked to pay a bribe or informal fee.

Table 6: Heterogeneous effects by crime reporting & exposure to bribery

	Composite index of police performance	
Muslim	-0.00 (0.01)	-0.00 (0.01)
Poor	-0.09*** (0.01)	-0.09*** (0.01)
Illiterate	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.02* (0.01)
Connected	0.07*** (0.01)	0.08*** (0.01)
Reported crime	0.01 (0.02)	
Reported crime $\times$ Muslim	0.00 (0.02)	
Reported crime $\times$ Poor	-0.03 (0.02)	
Reported crime $\times$ Illiterate	0.00 (0.02)	
Reported crime $\times$ Connected	0.02 (0.02)	
Reported crime & paid bribe		-0.00 (0.03)
Reported crime & paid bribe $\times$ Muslim		0.01 (0.03)
Reported crime & paid bribe $\times$ Poor		-0.07* (0.03)
Reported crime & paid bribe $\times$ Illiterate		-0.02 (0.03)
Reported crime & paid bribe $\times$ Connected		0.01 (0.03)
N	3788	3788

Robust standard errors in parenthesis, clustered by respondent.* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Composite index is standardized with mean 0 and standard deviation 1.

8 CONCLUSION

Ensuring that rank-and-file officers adhere to standards of professionalism, fairness, and impartiality is a challenge for police departments the world over, but nowhere more so than in weak and fragile states, where resource constraints and principal-agent problems are pervasive. In these settings, many rank-and-file officers shirk, solicit bribes, and engage in other forms of petty corruption because they are underpaid, and because they recognize that their commanders lack either the will or the ability to monitor their behavior.

Not only do these challenges undermine public trust and cooperation (Tyler 2004), they also raise concerns about equity. Theories of bureaucratic bias suggest that accountability failures provide ample room for rank-and-file officers to engage in misconduct or to discriminate on the basis of their personal biases. Bargaining power theories of corruption predict that citizens who are poor and uneducated may be especially vulnerable to police misconduct, as these individuals lack the knowledge and skills required to advocate for their rights through formal accountability mechanisms. And a large literature on neopatrimonialism suggests that accountability failures can lead to favoritism towards politically connected individuals who can leverage their connections to pressure bureaucrats through informal channels.

This paper tests for discrimination along these dimensions among those reporting crimes to the police. Drawing on original crime-level data on reporting and case outcomes for 2600 incidents of crime, I find that while acts of shirking and petty bribery are common in general, individuals who are poor, lacking in education, or who identify with the religious minority do not appear to be more vulnerable to these behaviors than others. After controlling for a range of case-level factors, members of these groups are not significantly more or less likely to be satisfied with how they were treated, to experience successful case outcomes, or to report crimes in the first place, as compared to the rest of the population. I do, however, find evidence that politically connected individuals are favored by the police. Compared to those without connections, these individuals are significantly more likely report crimes, to be satisfied with how they were treated, and to experience successful

case outcomes.

I find a similar set of patterns using data from a conjoint experiment designed to elicit respondents' expectations about police discrimination. Whereas expected performance is the same for Muslim and non-Muslim victims and nearly the same for victims with low versus high levels of education, expected performance is roughly .08 standard deviations higher for politically connected victims relative to unconnected victims. And while I find expected performance is on average .10 standard deviations lower for victims who are poor relative to victims who are wealthy, this effect appears to be driven by a) the expectation that the poor will not be able to pay informal fees, resulting in fewer resources for the investigation, and b) the conflation of the police's "fee-for-service" model of service delivery — which the crime-level data indicates is applied without regard to socio-economic status — with discrimination against the poor. But while the police's practice of charging fees to investigate crimes may have a *disparate impact* on the poor, it does not constitute a violation of legal principles forbidding *disparate treatment*.

Though I cannot decisively identify the mechanism underlying favoritism towards the politically connected, I have argued that this finding is consistent with the idea that, in settings characterized by patronage and patrimonial forms of governance, informal channels of accountability rooted in personal connections to politically powerful individuals are more effective than formal channels grounded in bureaucratic rules, hierarchies, and reporting mechanisms. In Liberia, access to state resources has long been more closely associated with personal connections to elites in government than with the rules and guidelines set by law. These power relations persist today (Sawyer 2008), and are likely to be one of the reasons why individuals with connections to government elites receive better services from the police and greater access to justice when victimized by crime.

The idea that informal channels of accountability trump formal channels rooted in rules and bureaucratic hierarchy is also consistent with the null effects on income and education, for if formal channels were effective, then we would expect those best positioned to pressure for better performance through these channels — i.e. those with a steady income, education, and knowledge

of the law and formal avenues of recourse — to be more successful at doing so than individuals without these skills and resources, and thus to report greater satisfaction and more successful case outcomes. That fact that we do not observe these patterns may suggest these formal, rule-based channels are ineffective.

For scholars and policymakers interested in police reform in weak and fragile states, these results provide both cause for optimism and cause for concern. On the one hand, the fact that rank-and-file police don't appear to exhibit religious or class-based biases is encouraging, especially given the apparent strength of these biases in the informal sector, and more generally, the long history of ethnic, religious, and class-based cleavages in Liberia. In this regard, the null effects on class and religious discrimination allude to the potential for formal-sector institutions to serve as fair and impartial providers of justice and security, even in weak states with highly salient social cleavages. That these null results come from Liberia, a seemingly “most likely” case for discrimination, should give pause to those characterizing bureaucratic bias as a “ubiquitous phenomenon” (Lipsky 1980, p. 111), and points to the need for further research on the factors and conditions that either cause or prevent such bias.

On the other hand, the fact that police performance is lackluster overall, and that sources of favoritism appear to stem from connections to elites in government rather than biases by rank-and-file officers, suggests that police officials and commanders are complicit in the production of discriminatory policing, and that failures of accountability stem from way power is controlled and exercised among these officials rather than from principal-agent problems between these officials and their rank-and-file. Moving forward, policymakers should consider directing their attention to this mid-to-upper tier of government, through reforms designed to ensure commanding officers distribute rather than hoard resources and equip rank-and-file officers with the resources they need to perform, even for those without political connections.

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Police Bias and Access to Justice: Evidence from Liberia

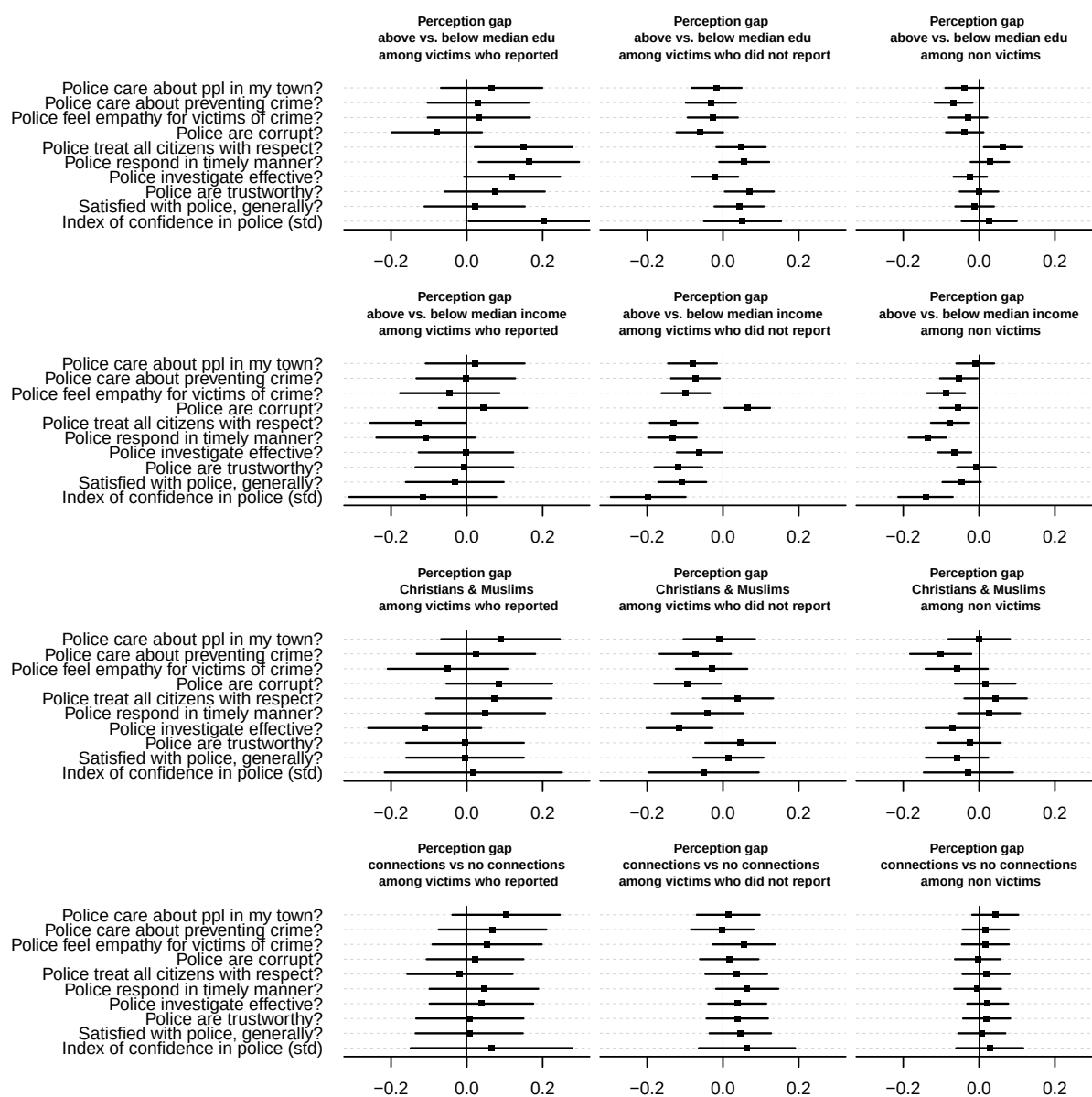
Online Appendix

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A.1 APPENDIX 1 TESTS OF SOCIAL DESIREABILITY BIAS

Figure A.1 displays differences in respondents' perceptions of the police in general, outside the context of their personal experience when reporting a crime, as a test of whether certain types of individuals are more likely to offer socially desirable responses, whether when asked questions about reported crimes or the police in general. To ensure this placebo analysis is not itself confounded by post-treatment bias among those reporting crimes to the police, Figure A.1 displays differences in perceptions among those who were never a victim of a crime ($N=1,142$) as well as those who were a victim of crime but did not report it to the police ($N=724$), in addition to differences among those who were a victim of a crime that was reported ($N=214$). The results offer little evidence to suggest social desirability bias influences the results. Across all three subgroups, differences in perceptions between Muslims and Christians, individuals with and without political connections, and individuals with above versus below median education are small and statistically significant. Although individuals with below median income are less likely to report favorable views of the police, this suggests that if anything, the null effects of low income on police performance are downward rather than upward biased.

Figure A.1: Differences in perceptions of police by religion, income, education, and political-connections



Notes: Raw differences in perceptions of police by religion, income, education, and political-connections.

A.2 APPENDIX 2 COMPARISON OF POLITICALLY CONNECTED INDIVIDUALS TO THOSE WITHOUT CONNECTIONS

Table [A.1](#) provides a comparison of politically connected individuals to those without connections.

Table A.1: Comparison of politically connected individuals to those without connections

	(1) Related to govt official?
Below median wealth	-0.02 [0.02]
Below median education	0.03 [0.02]
Below median income	-0.04 [0.02]
Muslim	-0.07 [0.02]
Female	-0.08** [0.03]
Age	-0.00* [0.00]
Voted in 2011/2017	0.04 [0.04]
Voted for incumbent in 2011/2017	0.01 [0.02]
Bassa	-0.16* [0.07]
Gio	-0.12 [0.07]
Kissi	0.03 [0.11]
Kpelle	-0.07 [0.08]
Kru	0.07 [0.07]
Lorma	0.05 [0.11]
Mandingo	0.03 [0.11]
Vai	-0.01 [0.09]
Constant	0.29*** [0.08]
Observations	2546

Standard errors in brackets, clustered by community

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

A.3 APPENDIX 3 VIGNETTES USED IN THE CONJOINT EXPERIMENT

PART 1: GENDER, RELIGION, CRIME

THEFT OF PHONE

Let's say that during the rainy season, a [gender] named [Christian / Muslim name] had [ppronoun] phone stolen near [ppronoun] home in [Muslim / Christian town name]. After the incident, a neighbor came to [name] with information about who may have committed the crime and recommended [pronoun] report the case to the police for further investigation.

BURGLARY

Let's say that during the rainy season, a [vig_gender] named [Christian / Muslim name] had someone break into [vig_ppronoun] house in [Muslim / Christian town name] while [vig_pronoun] wasn't there and stole all of [vig_ppronoun] furniture and valuables. After the incident, a neighbor came to [name] with information

BURGLARY & AGGRAVATED ASSAULT

Let's say that during the rainy season, a [vig_gender] named [Christian / Muslim name] was assaulted with a cutlass at night near [vig_ppronoun] home in [Muslim / Christian town name]. After the incident, a neighbor came to [name] with information about who may have committed the crime and recommended [vig_pronoun] report the case to the police for further investigation.

PART 2: WEALTH, LITERACY, POLITICAL CONNECTIONS

POOR, ILLITERATE, UNCONNECTED

At first, [vig_name] was scared to take the case to the police because [vig_pronoun] is poor. [vig_pronoun] also is not a book person and doesn't know the law, and [vig_pronoun] just moved to Monrovia and doesn't know any big big people in government who can give [vig_ppronoun] advice. However, eventually [vig_pronoun] put [vig_ppronoun] worries aside and took time off from [vig_ppronoun] petty business to report the [vig_crime] to the police.

POOR, ILLITERATE, CONNECTED

At first, [vig_name] was scared to take the case to the police because [vig_pronoun] is poor. [vig_pronoun] also is [vig_pronoun] is not a book person and doesn't know

the law. However, after talking to [vig_ppronoun] uncle, who is a bigman in the government, [vig_pronoun] decided it was best to take the case to the police. Shortly thereafter, [vig_name] took time off from [vig_ppronoun] petty business and reported the [vig_crime] to the police.

POOR, LITERATE, CONNECTED

At first, [vig_name] was scared to take the case to the police because [vig_pronoun] is poor. Even though [vig_pronoun] can read and write and knows the law good good, [vig_pronoun] was still scared because [vig_pronoun] was poor. However, after talking to [vig_ppronoun] uncle, who is a bigman in the government, [vig_pronoun] decided it was best to take the case to the police anyway. Shortly thereafter, [vig_name] took time off from [vig_ppronoun] petty business to report the [vig_crime] to the police.

POOR, LITERATE, UNCONNECTED

At first, [vig_name] was scared to take the case to the police because [vig_pronoun] is poor. [vig_pronoun] can read and write and knows the law good good, but [vig_pronoun] just moved to and doesn't know any big big people in government who can give [vig_ppronoun] advice. However, eventually [vig_pronoun] put [vig_ppronoun] worries aside and took time off from [vig_ppronoun] petty business to report the [vig_crime] to the police.

RICH, ILLITERATE, UNCONNECTED

At first, [vig_name] was scared to take the case to the police. Even though [vig_pronoun] has plenty money from [vig_ppronoun] NGO job, [vig_pronoun] is not a book person and doesn't know the law, and [vig_pronoun] just moved to Monrovia and doesn't know any big big people in government who can give [vig_ppronoun] advice. However, eventually [vig_name] put [vig_ppronoun] worries aside and took time off from [vig_ppronoun] NGO job to report the [vig_crime] to the police.

RICH, ILLITERATE, CONNECTED

At first, [vig_name] was scared to take the case to the police. Even though [vig_pronoun] has plenty money from [vig_ppronoun] NGO job, [vig_pronoun] is not a book person and doesn't know the law. However, after talking to [vig_ppronoun] uncle, who is a bigman in the government, [vig_pronoun] decided it was best to take the case to the police. Shortly thereafter, [vig_name] took time off from [vig_ppronoun] NGO job and reported the [vig_crime] to the police.

RICH, LITERATE, CONNECTED

At first, [vig_name] was scared to take the case to the police. Even though [vig_pronoun] has plenty money from [vig_ppronoun] NGO job and [vig_pronoun] can read and write

and knows the law good good, [vig_pronoun] was still scared. However, after talking to [vig_ppronoun] uncle, who is a bigman in the government, [vig_pronoun] decided it was best to take the case to the police. Shortly thereafter, [vig_name] took time off from [vig_ppronoun] NGO job and reported the [vig_crime] to the police.

RICH, LITERATE, UNCONNECTED

At first, [vig_name] was scared to take the case to the police. Even though [vig_pronoun] has plenty money from [vig_ppronoun] NGO job and [vig_pronoun] can read and write and knows the law good good, [vig_pronoun] just moved to Monrovia and doesn't know any big big people in government who can give [vig_ppronoun] advice. However, [vig_name] eventually put [vig_ppronoun] worries aside and took time off from [vig_ppronoun] NGO job to report the [vig_crime] to the police.